2024 Seed Grant Call for Proposals

May 20, 2024

To whom it may concern,

In regard of the Call for Proposals for the 2024 Sociology Department Seed Grants, I'm submitting my application with all the requirements specified. My main field of research is political sociology and Marxist political economy. As the faculty in the department knows, I came to the program to study the relationship between antimining struggles, the capitalist reproduction process as a whole, and the situation of shared imperialism in the Andes of South America. This seed grant will fund the first stage of my research project by stablishing the empirical base for the analysis of the antimining contention in Ecuador, Colombia, and Peru, by the means of archival research in the construction of a protest event catalog of antimining campaigns of struggle, and the interviews and ethnography of the anti-mining struggles developing currently in the region.

My proposal will be coordinated and discussed with my Theis Chair William Robinson, who will be faculty advisor since the second year. My estimate year of graduation for the M.A. is spring 2025 and for the PhD in September 2028, and my email address for contact is: mejiavillena@ucsb.edu.

I'm attaching to this letter the complete proposal with the CV and cover letter.

Sincerely,

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The effects of anti-mining struggles over capital reproduction and shared imperialism in the Andes

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Purpose and objectives of the project

The projected study have two objectives: 1) the comparative analysis of three cases of anti-mining contention, and 2) the Marxist analysis of the impact of these struggles over the rate of surplus value and rate of profit of mining different capitals. The analysis of the class struggle involved in anti-mining contentious campaigns from a historical political sociology (Tilly 2008), can orient theoretically the evidence about the operation of the mechanism and processes of contention between the indigenous-peasantry and the imperialist mining bourgeoisie (Lust 2016; 2019; Veltmeyer 2022).
Nevertheless, the effects of the process of scale shift of anti-mining contention in the Andes should be addressed by a Marxist analysis of the impact of these anti-mining campaigns of struggle had over the profits of the transnational mining corporations since the beginnings of the XXI century. Both necessities for the advancement in the study of extractive contention in a multilevel polity approach (Imig and Tarrow 2001) are grounded also in the increasingly growing literature on geo-economics and geopolitical current affairs which consider the centrality of certain strategic resources with certain material features which determine its possibilities for production and transportation (Ross 2015; 2004).

Planned activities

Three initial exploratory case studies are proposed considering field work and archive research in Colombia, Ecuador, and Peru. The first objective will be accomplished by a combination of mixed methods starting with interviews to activists and scholars, I will select a subnational circumscription to initiate first archival research intended to build a catalog of protest events (Tilly 2002; Hutter 2014) useful to compare at least three campaigns of anti-mining struggles. In this phase of my sociology master thesis, the second objective will be accomplished by studying the contribution of Marx on the Book 3 of Capital and on his Economic Manuscript of 1864-1865 (Marx 2016) on the configuration of the rate of profit and it's further division, considering the contributions also made by the theories on imperialism, global capitalism, transnational capitalist class and state (Robinson 2022; 2020), and of hegemonic transitions (Arrighi and Silver 1999), but focusing on the concrete analysis of transnational mining production in the Andes.

Expected contributions of the project

The main contribution of this study to the international understanding of the world current affairs will be to develop a theoretically oriented and empirically prospective interpretation of the antimining struggles as a sector of a broader field of extractive contention which is in the core of the current geopolitical and geo-economic global affairs at a multilevel polity -

i.e.: the Ukrainian and Gaza-Palestina interstate conflicts-, and of the effects of this contentious campaigns on the profits made by transnational mining companies, as a subset of the extractive industry which is in voracious expansion since the 2000's.

Fund use and budget

The funding will be used to cost partially the fieldwork in Colombia, Ecuador, and Peru. Mainly the prize received will be used to cover the transportation costs for fieldwork.

Fieldwork transportation budget

Concept	Cost ($)	Description
Flight LAX-UIO	300	Air flight ticket Los Angeles – Quito (Ecuador)
Flight UIO-BOG	200	Air flight ticket Quito-Bogotá (Colombia)
Flight BOG-LIM	200	Air flight ticket Bogotá-Lima (Perú)
Flight LIM-LAX	300	Air flight ticket Lima-Los Angeles

Plan for follow up research

Every quarter I will submit a brief report on the use of the funds and the outcome of the research, indicating the execution proportion of the project budget and the achievement of progress in the fieldwork and archival research.

Cited references

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